



So close, yet so far: Chasing 355 to win, Baba Indrajith (R) and Vijay Shankar's 125-run stand almost won it for Tamil Nadu, but Karnataka held firm to eke out a draw. PTI

traditional heavyweight Karnataka seemed to settle for a draw on the final day of its last league game against Chandigarh to avoid meeting Saurashtra in the quarterfinal, instead preferring to face Vidarbha.

On the other hand, had Services' push for an innings-victory against Maharashtra on the final day of the league stage been successful, it would have pipped Saurashtra to the second spot in Group A.

Madhya Pradesh — the only unbeaten side in the league stage — and Andhra, a consistent but less fancied side, booked a quarterfinal clash, in a repeat of last year's fixture.

MP enjoyed a straightforward entry into the quarterfinals from Group D, with both departments clicking in unison for the 2021-22 champion. Its journey was in sharp contrast to Karnataka's brinksmanship. Mayank Agarwal's side tempted fate repeatedly, be it a 29-run escape against Tripura or a one-wicket win against Railways.

These two close shaves were sandwiched between one of the most dramatic batting collapses and an edge-of-the-seat blockbuster.

Chasing 110 against Gujarat, Karnataka succumbed to a six-run defeat after a 50-run opening stand between Agarwal and Devdutt Padikkal seemed to put the contest to bed. Then, in the Southern Derby against Tamil Nadu, it came perilously close to conceding a 355-run target after Baba Indrajith and Vijay Shankar joined forces for a 125-run alliance for the sixth wicket to pull off a run-chase for the ages. **Eventually, salvaging three points for the first-innings lead was as close as Karnataka came to breathing easy.**

That game, however, was Padikkal's ticket to a maiden Test call-up as the left-hander was drafted in the squad for India's third Test against England following his 151 in the first innings. Padikkal's breakout First Class season saw him hitting 556 runs in six innings at an average of 92.66, including three hundreds.

Meanwhile, Tamil Nadu's Baba Indrajith continued to make a strong case for higher honours even as he is handed a raw deal by selectors time and again. He notched up another 600-run season — his sixth in 10 seasons — and emerged as TN's crisis man. His omission from the 2023-24 South Zone squad for the Duleep Trophy and that an India A cap still eludes him add intrigue to Indrajith's non-selection.

Left-arm spinners Sai Kishore and S. Ajith Ram were also key architects of TN's uptick in First Class cricket, with the duo picking up 76 wickets between them. Opener N. Jagadeesan struck form with back-to-back scores of 245* and 321, helping his side obliterate Railways and Chandigarh with innings-victories.

While the youngsters made their performances speak, the veterans couldn't capture the attention of selectors. Despite a spate of injuries in India's squad for the ongoing Tests against England, Pujara's three hundreds and two fifties and an average of 78.1 wasn't enough to earn a recall. Mumbai skipper Ajinkya Rahane didn't help his case with just 112 runs in five matches at a dismal 16 runs per dismissal.

The long-time mainstays of India's